



REWRITING THE 3RD EDUCATION SOCIAL CONTRACT TO CREATE AN EQUITABLE SOCIETY FOR ALL



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Executive Summary

This research paper seeks to provide an overview of the Education Social Contract and what it means in creating an equitable society for all. This paper illuminates knowledge in the area of Education Social Contract in educational institutions to be well engaged in addressing the diverse needs of its stakeholders. Education remains a public good and a crucial tool in maintaining regional and national stability. Educational institutions are at the forefront of many innovations and have recently been recognized as fundamental pillars of a country's competitiveness. They do not exist independent of the community they belong. They are in constant interaction with their external environment, which requires that they are able to understand the needs of diverse stakeholders and their interests. Academic institutions are now seen to be addressing actual societal problems. Some of these include but not limited to issues like gender disparity, exclusion, climate change, unemployment, unequal access to education and poverty.

All these form part of their social contract. Creating a more equitable society is imperative to help create equal access to employment and other socio-economic opportunities which could lead to the attainment of other national and global goals.



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Educational Institutions and the Public

Educational institutions have evolved over the years. This evolution is manifested in the governance of these institutions as well as their management in pursuit of academic excellence and their ability to address pertinent issues confronting society. Universities are required to proffer solutions to problems such as climate change, unemployment, intercultural exchanges, economic development and the development. Most higher education scholars agree that universities around the world are facing increasing demands for change which may sometimes be conflicting (Chankseliani, Qoraboyev, & Gimranova, 2021). In the process of change-making and setting the pace for the institution's success, Higher Educational Institutions (HEIs) indulge in the engagement of diverse processes and seemingly tedious but worthwhile processes of change.



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These institutions are required to understand that they are not making such changes or development for only themselves but for the community they belong to and serve.

Higher education is at a crossroads with the prospect of a substantial rebalancing of internal and external authority, influence, and accountability in higher education governance (Maassen, 2014).

A growing concern about higher education institutions is the engagement of diverse stakeholders in contributing to economic development, climate actions, job creation, innovation, and ensuring social justice. Maassen (2014) submits that higher education needs a strong governance system to enhance the delivery of its societal and academic expectations.

The manner this system of governance is applied is normally determined by the nature of the social contract between the higher education institution and its society. According to Elston (1999), universities have been excessively engulfed with extensive research activities which have impeded their ability to always be in touch with their stakeholders or publics (Elston, 1999).

Neave (2006) explains that social contract formation as applied to educational institutions comes with some complexities that need to be addressed. It is situated in many competing forces or stakeholders that may have varied needs. Such stakeholders may include students, governments, accreditation bodies and even higher education institutions.

De Herdt et al. (2012) noted that investment in education can play an important role in reconstructing the social contract between educational institutions and the state after violent conflicts. The authors defined the challenge of post-conflict reconstruction in terms of the strengthening of the social contract between the state and its citizens. A social contract is to direct focus on what people expect of the state and how the state can respond to these expectations. For instance, regarding state reconstruction in Congo in the domain of education, there is a large and increasing gap between people's demand for public schools and the state's ability to fulfil it. Sobhy (2021) argued for the operationalization of social contract that builds on and expands concepts of "citizenship".



The article examined state and citizen obligations regarding the four parameters (4Ps) of protection, provision, participation and the production of hegemony. Sobhy (2021) attempted to examine the disintegration of the postcolonial welfarist social contract and the key features of its transformations before and after the Arab Uprisings. The youth experiences in Egyptian schools revealed a ‘lived social contract’ that is underpinned by selective retraction of protection, a collapse of provision, impoverishment and Islamization of participation and a resulting disengagement from the production of hegemony. In Egypt, and some other northern African countries, there seemed to be little or no engagement with students and student leaders in the governing of higher educational institutions. Bawa (2001) argued that the higher education sector should engage in a process that leads to the development and adoption of a social contract between itself and the people (including the students that it immediately serves) of South Africa as it engages with the local and global challenges that face it.

Schugurensky (2007) examined dimensions of poverty and equality of educational opportunity in the higher education sector in the era of the neoliberal economy and their implications for social justice. The author considered the role that universities should be playing – and the role that they were actually playing – in promoting social justice. The author argued that universities are becoming more heteronomous. As such, they are losing the capacity to promote the common good and to pursue the search for truth in an autonomous way. Patel (2013) revealed formal education has inequality-reducing characteristics in the USA. The intended purpose of schools is to attend to children and youth’s needs by providing safe havens for them during school days. According to the research, schools were being treated based on race and class instead of creating a safe arena for all children. This paper interrogates these notions and the extent to which they influence the nature of the relationship that exists between management and students, and how this can translate into the success or failure of HEIs.

The paper also answers the question of why some universities are not engaging students in governance and what the perceptions both students and management hold about student leadership. Considering the social contract that exists between higher education institutions and the public, this research will also elucidate the emerging trends of the responsibility of HEIs to the public and its existential challenges.



Education, Diversity and Stakeholders

Social and economic modifications affecting every part of the world coupled with increasing globalization, ageing population, and recently the COVID-19 pandemic and its harsh impacts has placed a strong demand for everyone (including states and state actors) to reimagine approaches to almost everything. There is a strong demand to revisit those arrangements that are needed to create a more equitable and sustainable society for all. Education is one of the key areas that we have to revisit keenly to create a deeper understanding of “what is” and “what could be” in fostering and equitable society. Education remains a public good and a crucial tool in maintaining regional and national stability. Educational institutions are at the forefront of many innovations and have recently been recognized as fundamental pillars of a country's competitiveness. They do not exist independent of the community they belong to. They are in constant interaction with their external environment, which requires some understanding of the needs and interests of their diverse stakeholders. Thus, such institutions have ‘hidden’ or in some cases explicitly stated social contracts which they owe to their publics. Whatever the case may be, the end goal of such social contracts is the need to ensure that institutions are well engaged in the development and advancement of societies.

Educational institutions have diverse stakeholders. The interests of these stakeholders converge to create the social contract. Fonseca, Encarnação and Justino (2014), indicate how major events have structurally transformed education systems around the world. We have seen how COVID-19 is causing stakeholders to rethink approaches to pedagogy. Such transformations have emphasized the importance of engaging all stakeholders as equal partners in realizing educational goals.

For instance, it is easy to conclude that the key to the achievements of Higher Education Institutions is the effectiveness of their management and their ability to involve and engage the efforts and contributions of diverse stakeholders that include students and their leaders towards these achievements. Over the past decades, students have made significant contributions to the effectiveness of their schools through their participation in the school's operations. Student Representative Councils (SRCs) have become a common feature in post-primary schools and have worked to the benefit of many schools through their contribution to the development of school policies. Therefore, higher education institutions, for instance, must take intentional actions to involve all students as partners in ensuring and improving their educational experience, both individually and collectively. Further, HEIs must carefully rethink their position in society and assess their relationships with their various constituencies, stakeholders (especially students) and societies.



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At all levels, there must be arrangements in place for the effective expression of the collective student voice to enable all students to have their voices heard. In recent years, universities have made it possible for students to participate in university governance in various capacities. This was necessitated by the urge of university management to democratize the institution. Many African universities have been hit by student unrest in the past, resulting in property destruction during these violent protests and police standoffs. Universities have been closed in some in lost learning time.



Students' involvement in university governance is thought to prevent such protests and their repercussions. Luescher (2005) defines students' involvement in university governance as the participation of students as active agents in the governance of higher education. According to Luescher (2011), student involvement is a proactive measure to enhance teaching, learning and research, managing diverse student expectations and even enhance institutional finance, policy and strategy. Akomolafe and Ibijola (2011) argue that participating in university governance gives the student body a sense of belonging, a feeling of self-direction and is a source of motivation.

Despite these benefits of successful student-management partnerships, voting rights of students, according to Bergan (2004), are restricted in most countries to matters that seem to be of most immediate concern to students and do not extend to issues regarding staff assignments, administrative finance issues, curricula, or issues related to the award of degrees. This indicates that the management of Higher Education Institutions does not fully engage students in the decision-making process.

In recent times, students have shown the readiness, ability and willingness to engage in diverse matters. This has been functional in defending the rights of students as well as ensuring the success of academic institutions. Students perceive themselves as bona fide members of the university or higher education institutions which require their time and commitment. However, there have been contrary notions to the above, concerning the willingness and ability of students to engage in actions and discourses that will lead to the success of any HEI.





Education Social Contract in the 21st Century

Bawa (2000), shares how the historic past of South Africa has shaped or pre-determined its educational value system, mission and activities and the role that education institutions are supposed to play in societies. It is imperative for institutions and state actors to continually reimagine and rethink approaches to “social contracting” as the needs and interests of stakeholders, especially the learners, are constantly evolving. In the 21st century, we have seen increased demands for distance, open and e-learning due to the varying situations in so many countries and the need to establish equal and easy access to education for all. As has been seen in so many scenarios, education has received its biggest disruption amidst the COVID-19 pandemic. And, yes, we have to rethink what demands will be placed on all stakeholders in a social contract in any educational setting.

Perhaps in the 21st century, inclusivity and social justice should be at the core of “social contracting”. So many children continue to be left out of education due to no fault of theirs. As of 2018, UNESCO had reported that about 258 million children and youth are out of school. These numbers continue to grow as a result of so many disasters such as the COVID-19 pandemic, and inadequate staff and infrastructures.

In the classroom, for instance, to promote tolerance, inclusivity and equal access to education, we have to reimagine the rules in the classroom and how they affect actual learning outcomes for all students. Establishing the needed ground rules in the classroom as to how students should behave, how students should relate with each other, and the basis for rewarding marks is key to building the confidence of students and enhancing the attainment of learning outcomes.

It is important to note that every educational setting can thrive with the support of its stakeholders if they are in constant interaction with each other to address key issues considered as important. In the same trajectory, managers or leaders of academic institutions should be able to build an institutional culture that emphasizes the need for continual engagement at all times. According to the African Standards Guidelines (ASG-QA, 2018), most successful institutions are continually engaging stakeholders such as students and student leaders in the governance of their institutions. What will define a successful academic institution is its ability to properly address the interests of stakeholders in a holistic manner and in a way that posits the need for inclusivity and innovation.

Conclusion

Living standards in emerging economies have changed dramatically in the first two decades of the twenty-first century as a result of technological disruptions, globalization, the 2008 financial crisis and its recovery, shifting business and institutional structures. Education has not been left out of these changes.

Generally, education systems are not established for perfunctory reasons. Rather, they are established to provide knowledge and address the needed issues through research and innovative actions. Education faces threats, especially for children living in disaster and conflict zones, which in turn affects the aspirations and future of millions of children.

Education and education institutions are supposed to be a haven for children and young people. Hence, once they are not able to provide such an environment for a harmonious co-existence, then they are not able to address the needed change in the broader society. It is required that academic institutions be equipped with the right staff and infrastructure needed to ensure that they are addressing key issues in society as per the interests of diverse stakeholders. The scope of education institutions is broadening and they need to start thinking of new ways to address matters such as inclusivity, sustainability and the infiltration of technological advances and globalization.

This paper provided a broader understanding of what the responsibilities are for an academic institution in a social contract. It sheds light on the urgency of institutions to rethink new approaches to “social contracting” and the steps they can take to address the needs of diverse stakeholders.

It is expected that academic institutions should be addressing issues that are needed to ensure social justice, equitable society and a conducive study environment for all.





Recommendations

- 1.** Educational institutions should conduct a new stakeholder analysis and understand the extent to which they should engage their numerous stakeholders
- 2.** Education institutions should institute actual policies on how they intend to engage with their different stakeholders
- 3.** Pedagogy should become more student-centered.
- 4.** Education institutions should rethink approaches to addressing the diverse needs of their publics

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